

Easton Steffen

I analyzed baseball journalists Katie Woo and Mark Sheldon. I looked at both of their Instagram profiles for this assignment. Woo works for The Athletic as a beat writer for the LA Dodgers. Sheldon works for MLB as a reporter covering the Cincinnati Reds. Looking at their posts, they are very different from each other. Sheldon tends to post Reels telling the viewer what he has learned. It's like he is giving an overview of an article, just the highlights, just what you need to know. Sheldon also makes videos to post as well. For example, he has a video about Opening Day showing how the Reds are getting ready for the game. Woo seems to use her Instagram as anyone else would. She posts photos not only of herself at games or at the diamond but also of significant events in her life, like weddings. The most, she posts about regarding sports or her job as a writer for the Dodgers are photos of her at the field or other MLB areas talking to people. She does not use her Instagram as a way to promote her writing.

The type of information provided is also very different between the two. Woo shares still images of her life with minimal descriptions. The information provided is extremely limited, and any information that does come across it doesn't really tell you much about what she is writing about. Sheldon, on the other hand, shares a lot of information. He posts many Reels, which inherently share more information than photos do. Sheldon also shares information about what he is reporting on during these videos. In Sheldon's most recent Reel, he talks about one player's ongoing recovery from blisters and what the timeline looks like. He shares enough information to satisfy the desire to know what is going on, but not so much that it feels invasive or overwhelming.

The frequency of their posts is different. Sheldon posts once every few days. On big days like opening day, he will post more than once. Woo, on the other hand, posts about once a month. She will post multiple photos, like an end-of-month highlight, in these posts. I was surprised that Woo uses her Instagram as most people do, posting like once a month about what they have done, while Sheldon uses his as a place to share and promote his reporting.

Moving forward, I think that more media members will start using their social media to promote their work. Right now, we have a split between using it as most do and using it to promote their work. I think that we will see more people using social media as Sheldon does than as Woo does.

The 3 athletes I looked at were MLB players Jeremy Peña, Yoshinobu Yamamoto, and Vladimir Guerrero Jr. I will be looking at their Instagram accounts and specifically looking at posts from March 1, 2026, to today. There is not a ton posted during this time, as it is leading up to and the start of the season. I thought it would be good to look at what they are posting prior to the season starting, hence, picking MLB.

Starting with Peña, since March 1st, he has made 4 posts. The oldest post is from March 2nd and is an ad for an injury attorney that Peña starred in. On March 3rd, he posted about representing the Dominican Republic in the World Baseball Classic (WBC). The next day, he posted a Reel of him hitting a triple in one of the WBC games. Finally, the most recent post, April 4th, was celebrating Peña hitting his 600th career hit. There is a graphic and a Reel showing the hit.

Yamamoto has made 3 posts since the start of March. On March 1st, Yamamoto posted about spring training being over and announced that he will be playing for Japan

in the WBC. This post featured some images of Yamamoto, an LA Dodgers team photo, a picture of Yamamoto's teammate and their dog, and the Arizona landscape. The next post, March 10th, is about a collaboration between Yamamoto and Yoshi for a Yoshi bobblehead wearing an LA Dodgers hat and jersey featuring Yamamoto's number on it. The most recent post is from March 16th, and it announces that Yamamoto will be the opening day starter for the Dodgers with a collage graphic.

Guerrero Jr. has posted 9 times since March 1st. On March 2nd, Guerrero made a post announcing that he would be representing the Dominican Republic in the WBC with a photo of him in his jersey. On the 8th, Guerrero posted a Reel highlighting his home run in one of the WBC games. The following day, he posted photos from the home run moment he shared a Reel from the previous day. On March 12th, Guerrero posted 8 photos from another WBC game where he hit a home run. On the 13th, he posted a photo comparing two moments where Guerrero was going to home plate and went for a jumping dive. There is a video of both of these moments side by side as well. He also posted a video of just the jump dive from the WBC game. Guerrero posted next on the 16th, thanking the fans for supporting him and his team during the WBC. It features 12 photos of Guerrero during the WBC. From at-bats to signing things for fans, all of the photos show just how much fun he had. On March 29th, Guerrero posted 10 photos from the Toronto Blue Jays opening day game. This post features pictures of him during the national anthem, talking with teammates, and playing on the field. Guerrero's most recent post was posted on April 1st and announced that Guerrero would be partnering with FlexWork Sports as a brand ambassador. The post is just one photo graphic featuring Guerrero at FlexWork youth camps.

Comparing the 3 athletes, they don't post too often, but they do post when big things happen, like hitting a home run or getting a brand deal. The types of things they post are similar. It's either photos from a photo shoot, photos from a game, or videos from games. Most of the posts are about big things, such as playing in the WBC, becoming an ambassador for a brand, or hitting a home run. So most if not all of the athletes' posts are impactful or newsworthy. Some may be to a lesser degree than others. A pattern I noticed with these baseball players is that they are more likely to share about home runs than about other things that happen during games.

Athletes use social media to communicate with fans by sharing about big things going on in their careers. In regard to building a personal brand, athletes can establish this by how they share information, whether through video, text, or even photos. Guerrero's personal brand is to release edited videos of great moments and photos of him doing a variety of things, avoiding the standard baseball pictures of him hitting the ball. This is a personal brand. It does not appear that any of these athletes post on other social media platforms. If they do have accounts, I assume that they are not used.

Looking at the differences between how journalists and athletes use social media has been interesting. Journalists have more of an incentive to post because this gets more eyes on their work. Athletes have less of an incentive to post, but they still do.